



Strategic choice: Yastika Bhatia in action. India's management has shown faith in the left-hander at No. 3, where her ability to maximise the PowerPlay could prove valuable. AP

like her at number three after the dynamic Shafali and Smriti Mandhana. Then you've got Jemimah and Harmanpreet after who can steady the ship if you need to or kick on, and then you got Richa to kick on even more."

"With Yastika at No. 3, everyone then moves down one and it gives you a long batting line up," he added.

A situational approach

The solution could perhaps lie in a strategy India has dabbled with in the past: a flexible batting order based on entry points.

When batting in the top six, Yastika has appeared at her best, scoring more quickly both overall and during the first 10 balls of her innings. However, she tends to slow down as her innings progresses, with her strike rate outside the PowerPlay dropping in a manner that mirrors her overall decline in scoring rate.

That said, Yastika is the outlier here, having only recently returned to the international set-up and

played just a handful of games since 2024. Her numbers come with the caveat of a small sample size.

Even so, the willingness of the team management to give her three consecutive games at number three indicates there is some appetite for her as an option in that role.

For Jemimah, the numbers suggest she is stronger outside the PowerPlay. Both her overall strike rate and her strike rate in the first 10 balls of an innings rise significantly when she is batting between overs seven and 15.

A flexible approach may offer the best solution. If a wicket falls early,